

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 3

Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms (6th to 10th Centuries)

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	15 — Empires and Kingdoms (6th to 10th Centuries)
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. The post-Gupta age was a creative one of temples, universities, the rules of zero and Bhakti — not a 'dark age'; the Arabs conquered only Sindh in 712 CE and stayed confined to that foothold; and the contest for Kanauj was three-sided (tripartite among Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas), not a simple two-way fight. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. Two events are dated: Harshavardhana's rise to power and the Arab conquest of Sindh. Placed in correct chronological order, they are:

- (A) Harsha's rise (c. 606 CE) came first, then the Arab conquest of Sindh (712 CE)
- (B) the Arab conquest of Sindh (712 CE) came first, then Harsha's rise (c. 606 CE)
- (C) both happened in the same year, 712 CE
- (D) Harsha's rise came in 1206 CE, long after the conquest of Sindh

2. Xuanzang's account praises Harsha's just rule and the prosperity of Nalanda. A careful historian treats this glowing picture by:

- (A) accepting every detail as exact, since an eyewitness cannot be mistaken
- (B) rejecting it entirely, because foreign visitors never tell the truth
- (C) treating it as the only acceptable source, ignoring all Indian evidence
- (D) cross-checking it against inscriptions, coins and local records, because a single traveller's account can be partial or idealised

3. The Tripartite Struggle is so named because the contest for Kanauj involved:

- (A) two powers — the Palas and the Pratiharas only
- (B) three powers — the Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras of the Tamil south
- (C) three powers — the Chalukyas, Pallavas and Guptas
- (D) three powers — the Palas, the Gurjara-Pratiharas and the Rashtrakutas

4. Why did the Rashtrakutas of the Deccan repeatedly march all the way north to fight over Kanauj?

- (A) Kanauj was the only source of gold in the subcontinent
- (B) Control of Kanauj was a prized symbol of supremacy over northern India, worth contesting even from far away
- (C) the Rashtrakutas had no kingdom of their own and needed any city
- (D) Kanauj was a southern port the Rashtrakutas needed for sea trade

5. That the Tripartite Struggle dragged on for generations without any one power keeping Kanauj permanently best shows that the age was one of:

- (A) a single unbeatable empire ruling all of India
- (B) total peace with no political rivalry at all
- (C) foreign Arab rule over the whole north
- (D) a balance of several strong regional kingdoms, none able to dominate the rest for long

6. The Gurjara-Pratiharas held the north-west of the subcontinent. A direct consequence of this for the wider history of the period was that they:

- (A) opened the way for the Arabs to conquer the whole of north India
- (B) ended the Tripartite Struggle by surrendering Kanauj
- (C) helped block Arab expansion beyond Sindh, keeping Arab rule confined to that small foothold
- (D) built the Buddhist university of Nalanda in Bengal

7. Match each dynasty to the monument it is most associated with: Rashtrakutas, Pallavas, Palas.

- (A) Rashtrakutas — Kailasa temple at Ellora; Pallavas — rathas of Mahabalipuram; Palas — university of Nalanda
- (B) Rashtrakutas — Nalanda; Pallavas — Ellora; Palas — Mahabalipuram
- (C) Rashtrakutas — Mahabalipuram; Pallavas — Nalanda; Palas — Ellora
- (D) Rashtrakutas — Mahabalipuram; Pallavas — Ellora; Palas — Nalanda

8. The Kailasa temple at Ellora is described as 'monolithic'. What makes this an extraordinary achievement of the age?

- (A) The whole temple was carved downward out of a single mass of living rock, not built up from separate blocks
- (B) it was assembled from thousands of imported marble bricks
- (C) it was the largest wooden temple ever raised
- (D) it was the first temple made of cast iron

9. The Pallavas of Kanchi and the Chalukyas of Vatapi (Badami) are remembered partly for:

- (A) a firm alliance that united the whole south under one throne
- (B) ruling jointly over Bengal and its Buddhist universities
- (C) leading the Arab armies that conquered Sindh
- (D) a long-running rivalry between two southern powers, alongside the temple art each patronised

10. A 'ratha' at Mahabalipuram is best described as:

- (A) a self-governing village assembly
- (B) a large man-made reservoir for storing rainwater
- (C) a shrine carved from rock to resemble a chariot
- (D) a subordinate ruler who paid tribute

11. The Palas of Bengal are singled out in the chapter mainly for their patronage of:

- (A) the rock-cut rathas of Mahabalipuram
- (B) the monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora
- (C) great Buddhist centres of learning, especially Nalanda and Vikramashila
- (D) the Arab settlement of Sindh

12. Vikramashila admitted students only after they were examined by a 'dvarapandita' (gate-scholar). The best inference is that the university:

- (A) admitted anyone who arrived, with no selection at all
- (B) was actually a military camp rather than a place of study
- (C) taught only the rules of zero and nothing else
- (D) maintained high standards by testing applicants before admission

13. Both the Kailasa temple at Ellora and the rathas of Mahabalipuram are evidence that builders of this age had mastered:

- (A) the printing of illustrated books on paper
- (B) the minting of paper currency for trade
- (C) the casting of large structures in steel
- (D) the art of carving temples directly out of solid rock

14. In the south, alongside the Chalukyas and Pallavas, three ancient Tamil dynasties revived in this age. They were the:

- (A) Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras
- (B) Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas
- (C) Mauryas, Shungas and Satavahanas
- (D) Hunas, Shakas and Kushanas

15. The Chola Uttaramerur inscriptions are valued by historians chiefly because they record:

- (A) the method of carving a monolithic rock temple
- (B) Brahmagupta's rules for calculating with zero
- (C) the terms of the Arab settlement in Sindh
- (D) detailed rules for choosing the members of a village assembly (sabha)

- 16.** A king of this age is said to have ruled through 'samantas'. This means royal authority over outlying regions was exercised by:
- (A) directly appointed salaried officials reporting daily to the capital
 - (B) elected representatives chosen by a nationwide vote
 - (C) foreign Arab governors sent from Sindh
 - (D) subordinate rulers who governed in the king's name in return for tribute and troops
- 17.** The existence of self-governing village sabhas beneath the kings shows that political power in this age:
- (A) reached every individual villager directly from the king
 - (B) flowed downward through many hands, from king to samantas to village assemblies, not straight to each villager
 - (C) rested entirely with a single national parliament
 - (D) belonged only to foreign Arab rulers
- 18.** A 'land grant' recorded on a copper plate in this age typically:
- (A) gave land (often tax rights over it) to a person, temple or community, creating a class of landholders
 - (B) confiscated all land from villagers and gave them nothing
 - (C) was a devotional Tamil poem addressed to a deity
 - (D) described a chariot-shaped temple carved from rock
- 19.** Merchant guilds, busy market towns and trade routes in this period are evidence that the economy of the post-Gupta age was:
- (A) completely destroyed and reduced to ruin
 - (B) active and prosperous, contradicting any idea of total decline
 - (C) limited to silent barter with no organised trade
 - (D) wholly controlled by Arab merchants from Sindh
- 20.** A 'tank' (Tamil eri) built and maintained in a Chola village was a:
- (A) war chariot used in cavalry battles
 - (B) large man-made reservoir storing rainwater for irrigation and daily use
 - (C) Buddhist monastery for travelling monks
 - (D) subordinate ruler who paid tribute to the Cholas
- 21.** Land grants, merchant guilds and irrigation tanks, taken together, best show that the age combined:
- (A) total economic ruin and the end of farming
 - (B) a productive economy with deliberate management of land and water
 - (C) a complete absence of trade or money
 - (D) a society with no landholders of any kind
- 22.** The chapter argues against calling the post-Gupta centuries a 'dark age'. The strongest single piece of evidence for its view is that the period produced:

- (A) great temples, famous universities, the rules of zero and the Bhakti tradition
- (B) no building, learning or religious thought of any kind
- (C) constant defeat at the hands of foreign powers
- (D) the complete disappearance of Indian culture

23. Brahmagupta, a mathematician of this age, is remembered for:

- (A) writing the Rajatarangini, a history of Kashmir
- (B) leading the Arab conquest of Sindh
- (C) setting down rules for calculating with zero as a number
- (D) founding the twelve Alvar poet-saints of the south

24. That an Indian scholar set out the rules for zero in this very period is often cited to refute which mistaken claim?

- (A) that the Arabs conquered only Sindh in 712 CE
- (B) that the Tripartite Struggle was fought over Kanauj
- (C) that the post-Gupta age was an intellectually barren 'dark age'
- (D) that the Pallavas built the rathas of Mahabalipuram

25. The Bhakti tradition is described as beginning in the:

- (A) Arab-ruled region of Sindh
- (B) Central Asian steppe beyond the mountains
- (C) Himalayan north, around Kanauj
- (D) Tamil south, with poet-saints who sang devotion in the local language

26. How did the Bhakti way of worship differ from the older, formal Vedic tradition?

- (A) It stressed personal, loving devotion to a deity and was open to people of all backgrounds
- (B) it relied entirely on grand public sacrifices performed by priests
- (C) it was closed to everyone except kings and nobles
- (D) it was a foreign religion brought by the Arabs into Sindh

27. The Alvars and the Nayanars, the early Bhakti poet-saints, are correctly distinguished as:

- (A) Alvars devoted to Shiva, Nayanars devoted to Vishnu
- (B) Alvars devoted to Vishnu, Nayanars devoted to Shiva
- (C) both groups devoted only to the Buddha
- (D) Alvars Chinese pilgrims, Nayanars Arab generals

28. The Arab conquest of 712 CE is best summarised as:

- (A) the conquest of the whole subcontinent in a single campaign
- (B) an attack that never actually reached Indian soil
- (C) the start of unbroken Arab rule over India until modern times
- (D) the capture of Sindh alone, after which Arab rule stayed confined to that small foothold for a long time

- 29.** Why did Arab expansion fail to spread far beyond Sindh after 712 CE?
- (A) there was no Indian resistance, but the Arabs simply chose to stop
 - (B) the Chinese army marched in and drove the Arabs back
 - (C) the whole of India had already been conquered, leaving nothing more to take
 - (D) Strong Indian rulers, notably the Gurjara-Pratiharas and Kashmir's Lalitaditya, resisted and contained the advance
- 30.** A student writes: 'After the Guptas India fell into a dark age, the Arabs conquered most of it in 712, and the Tripartite Struggle was a two-power fight.' How many of these three statements are wrong?
- (A) none — all three are correct
 - (B) only one
 - (C) only two
 - (D) all three
- 31.** The period from roughly 600 to 1200 CE in India is best characterised politically as:
- (A) one vast empire stretching across the whole land
 - (B) a subcontinent with no single empire but many strong, competing regional kingdoms
 - (C) a region with no kingdoms or organised states at all
 - (D) a land ruled entirely by Arab governors
- 32.** 'Epigraphy' helps historians of this age because it is the study of:
- (A) coins and the metals from which they are struck
 - (B) the movements of stars and planets
 - (C) old travel diaries written by foreign visitors
 - (D) inscriptions carved on stone or metal, such as copper-plate grants and temple records
- 33.** A royal 'prashasti' inscription must be read with caution because it:
- (A) praises the ruler and may exaggerate or omit his failures
 - (B) was written by the king's bitterest enemies
 - (C) is always perfectly neutral and exact
 - (D) records only the ordinary affairs of village life
- 34.** The Rajatarangini is unusual among early Indian texts because it is:
- (A) Kalhana's twelfth-century work setting down the history of Kashmir's dynasties in chronological order
 - (B) Brahmagupta's treatise on the rules of zero
 - (C) a Tamil devotional poem composed by an Alvar
 - (D) an Arab official's account of the conquest of Sindh
- 35.** Why does the chapter point out that the caste (varna-jati) system of this age was flexible rather than completely fixed?
- (A) because there were in fact no jatis at all in this period
 - (B) Because status could change over time and varied by region — for example, the Palas are said to have risen from a humbler background to kingship

- (C) because every person in India belonged to a single, identical group
- (D) because caste was abolished entirely by royal decree

36. The Kayasthas are given in the chapter as an example of how, in this age:

- (A) a jati once formed could never change in any way
- (B) foreigners came to rule the whole of India
- (C) a profession or occupation could harden into a distinct jati over time
- (D) temples were carved out of single blocks of rock

37. That jatis multiplied and some families shifted status across this period indicates that the social system was:

- (A) perfectly simple and absolutely unchanging
- (B) completely abolished in this age
- (C) complex and changing, not frozen for all time
- (D) identical in every region of India

38. The chapter notes that, in this age, some queens and women:

- (A) were entirely absent from public life
- (B) each ruled the whole subcontinent on their own
- (C) were forbidden any role outside the home
- (D) held real influence and exercised power in public affairs

39. Assertion: After the Guptas, the north lacked a single dominant emperor for a long time. Reason: This is why several regional powers fought the Tripartite Struggle. Which is correct?

- (A) Both are true, but the reason does not explain the assertion
- (B) The assertion is true but the reason is false
- (C) Both the assertion and the reason are true, and the reason explains the assertion
- (D) The assertion is false but the reason is true

40. Assertion: The Arabs ruled most of India after 712 CE. Reason: They captured Sindh in that year. Which is correct?

- (A) The assertion is false, but the reason is true
- (B) Both are true and the reason explains the assertion
- (C) Both are false
- (D) The assertion is true but the reason is false

41. Of the following, which correctly orders three powers from north-west to east across the subcontinent?

- (A) Palas (north-west) — Pratiharas (Deccan) — Rashtrakutas (east)
- (B) Gurjara-Pratiharas (north-west) — Rashtrakutas (Deccan) — Palas (Bengal in the east)
- (C) Rashtrakutas (north-west) — Palas (Deccan) — Pratiharas (east)
- (D) Pallavas (north-west) — Cholas (Deccan) — Cheras (east)

- 42.** A copper-plate grant praises a king lavishly and lists conquests, while a neighbouring kingdom's inscription claims it defeated that same king. A careful historian concludes that:
- (A) the first inscription must be wholly true because it is longer
 - (B) each inscription may be biased toward its own ruler, so the truth lies in weighing both against other evidence
 - (C) both inscriptions are worthless and should be ignored
 - (D) whichever inscription is older is automatically correct
- 43.** Which pairing of a ruler/people with the right region is correct?
- (A) Pallavas — Bengal; Chalukyas — Kashmir
 - (B) Pallavas — Vatapi in the Deccan; Chalukyas — Kanchi in the Tamil region
 - (C) Pallavas — Kanchi in the Tamil region; Chalukyas — Vatapi (Badami) in the Deccan
 - (D) Pallavas — Sindh; Chalukyas — Kanauj
- 44.** Xuanzang was a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim. The fact that he was a Buddhist monk helps explain why his account:
- (A) ignores religion completely and describes only warfare
 - (B) praises only the Arab rulers of Sindh
 - (C) gives especially detailed and admiring descriptions of Buddhist centres such as Nalanda
 - (D) was written entirely in the Tamil language
- 45.** If a historian wanted firsthand evidence about how Chola villages chose the members of their assemblies, the best source would be:
- (A) Xuanzang's travel account of Harsha's India
 - (B) Brahmagupta's rules for working with zero
 - (C) the Uttaramerur inscriptions
 - (D) the Rajatarangini's history of Kashmir
- 46.** Which statement best captures the relationship between political fragmentation and cultural life in this age?
- (A) Even without a single empire, the many kingdoms competed as patrons, and culture flourished
 - (B) political fragmentation always destroys art and learning
 - (C) culture flourished only because one emperor ruled everything
 - (D) the absence of an empire meant no temples were ever built
- 47.** Harshavardhana is often called the last great ruler to dominate the north for this era. The clearest sign that his dominance did not outlast him is that, afterwards:
- (A) one of his successors ruled unchallenged for centuries
 - (B) the Arabs immediately conquered the whole north
 - (C) no single emperor held the north, and rival powers contested Kanauj in the Tripartite Struggle
 - (D) all northern kingdoms peacefully merged into one

48. Compared with the Pallava rathas of Mahabalipuram, the Rashtrakuta Kailasa temple at Ellora is especially noted for being:

- (A) built of fired brick rather than cut from stone
- (B) a Buddhist university rather than a temple
- (C) a chariot too small to enter
- (D) a single, much larger monolithic temple carved downward from one rock mass

49. Which sequence correctly orders these by date, earliest first: Brahmagupta's mathematical work (7th century), the Arab conquest of Sindh (8th century), Kalhana's Rajatarangini (12th century)?

- (A) Brahmagupta, then the conquest of Sindh, then the Rajatarangini
- (B) the Rajatarangini, then Brahmagupta, then the conquest of Sindh
- (C) the conquest of Sindh, then the Rajatarangini, then Brahmagupta
- (D) the Rajatarangini, then the conquest of Sindh, then Brahmagupta

50. A samanta supplies his overlord with tribute and troops but governs his own land. The most important effect of ruling through many such samantas was that:

- (A) royal authority was indirect and layered, so a king's real power depended on the loyalty of his subordinates
- (B) the king personally administered every village himself
- (C) samantas had no duties to the king at all
- (D) the king's power reached every individual through a national vote

51. Which best explains why historians prize village inscriptions and copper-plate grants for studying this age?

- (A) they are always written by neutral foreign observers
- (B) They record everyday matters — land, taxes, assemblies — that royal chronicles and travelogues often leave out
- (C) they describe only the personal feelings of kings
- (D) they are the only sources that ever exaggerate

52. The chapter's overall verdict on the centuries after the Guptas is that they were:

- (A) a stagnant 'dark age' of decline and gloom
- (B) a single peaceful empire with little change
- (C) a creative and dynamic age of regional kingdoms, great art, learning and new religious ideas
- (D) a period of complete foreign domination

53. Both the Palas (supporting Nalanda) and the Cholas (recording village rules at Uttaramerur) illustrate the same broad point about this age, namely that:

- (A) different regional kingdoms each fostered learning and institutions in their own way
- (B) only one empire in the north patronised any culture

- (C) kingdoms of this age destroyed schools and assemblies
- (D) all cultural life depended on Arab rulers in Sindh

54. Which contrast between Bhakti saints and the older Vedic priesthood is correctly stated?

- (A) Bhakti was conducted only in a language no one understood, while Vedic ritual used everyday speech
- (B) Bhakti reached ordinary people through devotion in local languages, whereas formal Vedic ritual was priest-centred
- (C) Bhakti was restricted to kings, while Vedic ritual was open to all
- (D) Bhakti and Vedic ritual were identical in every respect

55. An exhibit labels a tall stone shrine 'a monolithic ratha-style temple of the Tamil coast'. The dynasty most likely responsible is the:

- (A) Rashtrakutas
- (B) Pallavas
- (C) Palas
- (D) Gurjara-Pratiharas

56. Why is it misleading to say 'one source, Xuanzang, proves Harsha's India was prosperous'?

- (A) because Xuanzang never actually visited India
- (B) Because a single source can be partial, so its claims should be tested against inscriptions, coins and other records
- (C) because prosperity can never be judged from any source
- (D) because only coins, and nothing else, can prove anything

57. Which single statement is fully accurate about the Arab presence in the subcontinent in this age?

- (A) the Arabs conquered the whole of India and ruled it directly
- (B) the Arabs were defeated and never held any territory in the subcontinent
- (C) The Arabs held Sindh from 712 CE but were kept from expanding much further by Indian resistance
- (D) the Arabs ruled Bengal and the Tamil south but never Sindh

58. Nalanda and Vikramashila drew students and monks from distant lands across Asia. The best inference from this is that, in this age, India was:

- (A) cut off from all contact beyond its own borders
- (B) without any institutions of higher study
- (C) a respected centre of learning connected to a wider world by travel and exchange
- (D) ruled in its entirety by foreign Arab governors

59. Which pairing of a term with its meaning is correct?

- (A) Sabha — a subordinate ruler; samanta — a village assembly
- (B) Sabha — a village assembly; samanta — a subordinate ruler

(C) Sabha — a chariot-shaped temple; samanta — a water reservoir

(D) Sabha — a devotional poem; samanta — a Chinese pilgrim

60. Taken together, the rules of zero, the great universities, the rock-cut temples and the Bhakti hymns are used in the chapter to make one central argument, that:

(A) the post-Gupta centuries were a richly creative age, so the 'dark age' label is mistaken

(B) the post-Gupta centuries saw the end of all Indian achievement

(C) a single empire was responsible for every one of these achievements

(D) the Arabs of Sindh produced all of these achievements

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms (6th to 10th Centuries) — Paper 3

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	A	11	C	21	B	31	B	41	B	51	B
2	D	12	D	22	A	32	D	42	B	52	C
3	D	13	D	23	C	33	A	43	C	53	A
4	B	14	A	24	C	34	A	44	C	54	B
5	D	15	D	25	D	35	B	45	C	55	B
6	C	16	D	26	A	36	C	46	A	56	B
7	A	17	B	27	B	37	C	47	C	57	C
8	A	18	A	28	D	38	D	48	D	58	C
9	D	19	B	29	D	39	C	49	A	59	B
10	C	20	B	30	D	40	A	50	A	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (A) Harsha came to the throne around 606 CE, in the early seventh century, while the Arab capture of Sindh under Muhammad bin Qasim is dated to 712 CE — so Harsha is earlier by about a century. Reversing the order ignores that 606 is smaller than 712. The two are not the same year, and 1206 is the start of the Delhi Sultanate, far too late for Harsha.

2. (D) A traveller sees only part of a society, may misunderstand what he sees, and may favour places (like the Buddhist Nalanda) that match his own interests, so his account is one source to be cross-checked against inscriptions, coins and local records. Accepting every word uncritically forgets these limits; rejecting it wholesale wastes genuinely useful testimony; and making it the only source ignores the richer Indian evidence.

3. (D) 'Tri-' means three: the Palas of Bengal, the Gurjara-Pratiharas of the north-west and the Rashtrakutas of the Deccan all fought for Kanauj. Naming only two forgets the

Deccan power that repeatedly intervened. The Tamil trio (Cholas, Pandyas, Cheras) fought in the far south, not for Kanauj, and the Guptas had already faded before this contest began.

4. (B) Kanauj had become a symbol of paramount authority in the north, so holding it announced a ruler's supremacy — a prestige worth a long campaign. It was not uniquely rich in gold, the Rashtrakutas already held a powerful Deccan kingdom, and Kanauj sits inland in the Ganga plain, not on the coast.

5. (D) A contest that no side could finish means the rivals were roughly matched — the hallmark of several strong regional kingdoms in balance. A single empire or total peace would have ended the fighting at once, and the Arabs never ruled the north; they were confined to Sindh.

6. (C) Standing on the north-western frontier, the Pratiharas were the shield that absorbed and checked Arab pressure, so Arab power got no further than Sindh. They did not invite conquest; their resistance had the opposite effect. They were rivals, not surrenderers, in the Kanauj contest, and Nalanda was a Pala foundation in Bengal, far to the east.

7. (A) The Rashtrakutas of the Deccan are credited with the monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora; the Pallavas of Kanchi carved the rock-cut rathas at Mahabalipuram; and the Palas of Bengal patronised the Buddhist university of Nalanda. The other pairings swap these famous links, for instance crediting the southern Pallavas with the Deccan's Ellora or the Bengal Palas with a Tamil-coast monument.

8. (A) Monolithic means 'one stone': sculptors cut away the hillside to release a complete temple from a single rock, working top-down with no margin for error — a feat of planning and skill. Brick assembly, wood and cast iron all describe the opposite of carving from one rock, and none matches what Ellora actually is.

9. (D) The Pallavas (Kanchi) and Chalukyas (Vatapi) were neighbouring rivals whose wars are a feature of southern politics in this age, even as both sponsored fine temple architecture. They were competitors, not partners, ruled in the south rather than Bengal, and had nothing to do with the Arab conquest of distant Sindh.

10. (C) A ratha is literally a chariot, and at Mahabalipuram the Pallava sculptors cut shrines from rock in the shape of chariots. A village assembly is a sabha, a reservoir is a tank (eri), and a tribute-paying subordinate is a samanta — none of these is a temple form.

11. (C) The Pala kings supported Buddhism and the famous universities of Nalanda and Vikramashila, drawing scholars from across Asia. The Mahabalipuram rathas were Pallava work, Ellora's Kailasa was Rashtrakuta, and Sindh was the Arab foothold — none was a Pala project.

12. (D) A scholar stationed at the gate to test applicants is a screening device, which implies the institution guarded its quality and selectivity. Open admission with no test is the opposite of what a gate-examiner implies; a gate-scholar marks a place of learning, not an army camp; and a great university taught many subjects, not a single topic.

13. (D) Both monuments are rock-cut — the temple emerges from the stone itself rather than being assembled — so they showcase a shared mastery of carving rock. Paper printing, paper money and steel casting are unrelated technologies and describe none of these stone monuments.

14. (A) The Tamil south saw the old Chola, Pandya and Chera lines revive as strong kingdoms in this period. The Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas were the northern Tripartite trio; the Mauryas, Shungas and Satavahanas belong to much earlier centuries; and the Hunas, Shakas and Kushanas were foreign-origin powers of still earlier times.

15. (D) The Uttaramerur inscriptions lay out qualifications and a selection procedure for the village sabha, giving rare evidence of local self-government under the Cholas. They are not about temple carving, mathematics, or Sindh — those belong to Ellora, Brahmagupta and the Arabs respectively.

16. (D) A samanta was a lesser ruler who accepted the overlord, supplied tribute and soldiers, and governed his own territory — so the king ruled in layers, not directly. There was no salaried daily-reporting bureaucracy reaching every region, no nationwide election, and certainly no Arab governors outside the Sindh foothold.

17. (B) If villages ran many of their own affairs through a sabha and samantas governed the regions, then authority was layered, passing through intermediate hands rather than from the king to each person. A king touching every villager directly contradicts the layered system, there was no national parliament, and the Arabs held only Sindh.

18. (A) A land grant transferred land or its revenues to a recipient — a brahmana, temple or official — and over time produced a stratum of landholders, which is why these grants matter to social history. It did not strip villagers of everything; a devotional poem and a rock-cut shrine are entirely different things.

19. (B) Organised guilds and thriving towns are marks of a working, prosperous economy, so they refute the 'dark age' picture. A ruined economy would lack guilds and towns; barter-only trade would not need guilds; and the Arabs, confined to Sindh, did not control the subcontinent's commerce.

20. (B) An eri was an artificial water reservoir that captured rain for farming and household needs — evidence of careful water management. It was not a chariot, a monastery, or a subordinate ruler; those are unrelated things drawn from elsewhere in the chapter.

21. (B) Grants organised landholding, guilds organised trade, and tanks organised water — together they describe an economy that was managed and productive. Ruin, the absence of trade, or the absence of landholders each contradict at least one of these three institutions.

22. (A) Monuments, universities, mathematical breakthroughs and a new devotional movement are exactly the kind of creative achievements a 'dark age' supposedly lacks, so they overturn the label. The other options simply restate the discredited 'dark age' claim rather than answering it.

23. (C) Brahmagupta gave the world systematic rules for using zero in arithmetic — a landmark contribution that further disproves the 'dark age' idea. The Rajatarangini was Kalhana's work, the Sindh conquest was an Arab military event, and the Alvars were Tamil devotional poets — none of these is Brahmagupta.

24. (C) A major advance in mathematics during these very centuries is direct proof of intellectual vitality, so it specifically rebuts the 'dark age' charge. The other three statements are themselves correct facts, not claims that the rules of zero are used to refute.

25. (D) The earliest Bhakti saints — the Alvars and Nayanars — composed in Tamil in the south, so that is where the movement is said to begin. It did not arise in Arab Sindh, on the Central Asian steppe, or around Kanauj in the north.

26. (A) Bhakti centred on a direct, emotional bond between worshipper and god and welcomed people regardless of status, which set it apart from the priest-led sacrifices of earlier practice. It was not sacrifice-based, not restricted to royalty, and not an Arab import.

27. (B) The Alvars sang of Vishnu and the Nayanars of Shiva, both in Tamil — a standard pairing. Swapping their deities, making them both Buddhist, or turning them into pilgrims and generals all misidentify these Tamil devotional poets.

28. (D) In 712 the Arabs took Sindh and then made little further headway, so their power remained a limited frontier presence. They did not overrun all of India, they certainly reached India (Sindh is in the subcontinent), and their rule there did not stretch into modern times.

29. (D) Indian powers along and beyond the frontier — above all the Pratiharas and rulers like Lalitaditya of Kashmir — fought back and bottled the Arabs up in Sindh. It was active resistance, not a voluntary halt; the Chinese did not intervene; and India plainly had not been wholly conquered, since most of it remained in Indian hands.

30. (D) Each statement fails a key fact of the chapter: the age was creative, not dark; the Arabs took only Sindh, not most of India; and the Tripartite Struggle involved three powers, not two. Since every one is mistaken, the count of wrong statements is three.

31. (B) These centuries lacked any all-India empire but were full of powerful regional states — Palas, Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas, Cholas and others — competing with one another. There was no single empire, no absence of states, and no Arab rule outside Sindh.

32. (D) Epigraphy reads inscriptions cut into stone or metal, which preserve grants, genealogies and village rules from this period. Coins are the field of numismatics, stars belong to astronomy, and travel diaries are a separate kind of literary source.

33. (A) A prashasti is a panegyric composed to glorify the king, so it tends to magnify successes and pass over defeats — bias the historian must allow for. It was not written by enemies, is the opposite of neutral, and concerns the ruler's achievements rather than ordinary village affairs.

34. (A) Kalhana's Rajatarangini is a rare attempt at ordered, historical narrative — a chronicle of Kashmir's kings — which is why it stands out. It is not a mathematics text, a devotional poem, or an Arab account of Sindh.

35. (B) Examples like the Palas' rise and the regional variation of jatis show that social position was not frozen, so the 'completely rigid' label is wrong. The chapter does not deny that jatis existed, claim a single uniform group, or say caste was abolished — only that it could shift.

36. (C) The Kayasthas illustrate occupational groups becoming recognised jatis, showing that the social order was still forming and changing. This is the opposite of an unchangeable jati, and has nothing to do with foreign rule or rock-cut temples.

37. (C) Multiplying jatis and changing status are signs of a system in flux, so it was complex and evolving rather than fixed. It was neither simple-and-static, nor abolished, nor uniform everywhere — the regional variety is part of the point.

38. (D) Evidence of influential queens shows women could wield real authority in this period. They were neither wholly absent nor universally barred, but nor did any single woman rule the entire subcontinent — that overstates the case.

39. (C) Because no one emperor dominated the north, an opening existed for ambitious regional powers to compete for supremacy at Kanauj — so the power vacuum is exactly why the three-cornered struggle happened, making the reason a genuine explanation. Both statements are accurate, and they stand in a cause-and-effect relation.

40. (A) Capturing Sindh in 712 is a fact (the reason is true), but it did not lead to ruling most of India — Arab power stayed confined to that foothold, so the assertion is false. The capture of one province cannot support a claim of subcontinent-wide rule.

41. (B) The Pratiharas guarded the north-west, the Rashtrakutas held the Deccan in the centre-south, and the Palas lay in Bengal to the east — a genuine west-to-east sequence.

The other lists scramble these well-known territories or substitute the Tamil dynasties, which all belong to the far south, not a west-to-east line.

42. (B) Royal inscriptions glorify their own patron, so conflicting claims signal bias on both sides, and the historian must cross-check them against other sources. Length does not prove truth, both records still hold useful clues rather than being worthless, and mere age does not guarantee accuracy.

43. (C) The Pallavas ruled from Kanchi in the Tamil country and the Chalukyas from Vatapi (Badami) in the Deccan. Swapping their capitals, or placing them in Bengal, Kashmir, Sindh or Kanauj, all misassign these two southern powers.

44. (C) A Buddhist visitor naturally took close interest in Buddhist institutions, so his enthusiastic notes on places like Nalanda reflect his own faith — a useful caution for the historian. He did not ignore religion, had no reason to praise Sindh's Arabs, and wrote in Chinese, not Tamil.

45. (C) The Uttaramerur inscriptions set out the actual qualifications and selection rules for the village sabha, making them the direct evidence for Chola local government. Xuanzang described the north a century or more earlier, Brahmagupta wrote on mathematics, and the Rajatarangini concerns Kashmir's dynasties — none addresses Chola village elections.

46. (A) Rival kingdoms each sponsored temples, universities and poets to outshine their neighbours, so fragmentation went hand in hand with a creative flowering. It did not destroy culture; there was no single emperor; and temple-building plainly continued across the many states.

47. (C) That regional powers had to fight over Kanauj after Harsha shows no successor inherited his paramountcy — the north fragmented. There was no unchallenged heir, the Arabs did not seize the north, and the kingdoms competed rather than peacefully merging.

48. (D) Both are rock-cut, but Kailasa is a vast, complete temple released from one rock by cutting downward — a larger-scale feat than the smaller Mahabalipuram shrines. It is not brick, not a university (that describes Nalanda/Vikramashila), and it is a great temple, not a tiny chariot.

49. (A) Seventh century comes before eighth, which comes before twelfth, so the order runs Brahmagupta (7th), Sindh (8th), Rajatarangini (12th). The other orderings put the twelfth-century chronicle or the eighth-century conquest ahead of the seventh-century mathematician, breaking the timeline.

50. (A) Because samantas held real local power and could shift loyalties, the overlord's strength rested on keeping them faithful — authority was mediated, not direct. The king

did not run every village himself, samantas did owe tribute and troops, and there was no national vote in this system.

51. (B) Inscriptions and grants fix in stone or metal the practical details of land, revenue and local self-rule, filling gaps that king-centred narratives miss. They are not foreign-authored, not focused on royal feelings, and exaggeration is more a feature of prashastis than of routine grants.

52. (C) The chapter gathers temples, universities, mathematics, Bhakti and vigorous kingdoms to argue the era was creative and dynamic. This refutes the 'dark age' verdict, the idea of one static empire, and the notion of complete foreign rule — none of which fits the evidence.

53. (A) A Bengal dynasty backing a university and a southern dynasty codifying village self-rule both show regional powers actively building institutions of learning and governance. This contradicts the ideas that only one northern empire patronised culture, that kingdoms destroyed such institutions, or that culture depended on Sindh's Arabs.

54. (B) The Bhakti saints sang in Tamil and other local tongues and welcomed all, in contrast to the more exclusive, priest-led Vedic sacrifices. It is not true that Bhakti used an unintelligible language, that it was limited to kings, or that the two traditions were the same.

55. (B) Ratha-style rock-cut shrines on the Tamil coast point to the Pallavas of Kanchi and their work at Mahabalipuram. The Rashtrakutas built Ellora in the Deccan, the Palas patronised universities in eastern Bengal, and the Pratiharas held the distant north-west — none fits a Tamil-coast ratha.

56. (B) Relying on one observer risks accepting his limits and biases, so the responsible method is to corroborate him with independent evidence like inscriptions and coins. Xuanzang did visit India, prosperity can be studied through evidence, and coins are one useful source among several, not the only one.

57. (C) The accurate picture is a foothold in Sindh from 712 that Indian powers prevented from growing. The Arabs did not conquer all India, they did hold Sindh (so they were not wholly excluded), and they never ruled Bengal or the Tamil south.

58. (C) Scholars arriving from across Asia show that India's universities had international standing and that travel and exchange flourished, contradicting any picture of isolation. It was not cut off, it plainly had great institutions of study, and the Arabs held only Sindh, not the whole land.

59. (B) A sabha is the self-governing village assembly and a samanta is a tribute-paying subordinate ruler — two pillars of the layered politics of the age. Swapping the two, or equating them with a temple, reservoir, poem or pilgrim, misdefines both terms.

60. (A) Each item — mathematics, learning, art and devotion — is a creative achievement, and together they make the case that the era flourished rather than declined. They do not show an end of achievement, they came from many different kingdoms rather than one empire, and they were Indian, not Arab, accomplishments.